

The Mihai Eminescu Trust

A Very Happy Christmas

Newsletter and highlights of 2002

The Mihai Eminescu Trust was established in 1987 for the promotion of culture and education in Romania. Since 1999 the Trust has been concentrating on a project to promote the cultural and economic survival of the Saxon villages in Transylvania. In the 800 years since the Saxons populated the area it has remained extraordinarily intact as a mediaeval village landscape.

THE WILKIE REPORT on "The Saxon Villages of Transylvania – a Future for the Medieval Landscape", sponsored by HRH The Prince of Wales, was published at the beginning of the year on behalf of the MET. Press events were held in London and Romania. First was the launch at the Romanian Cultural Foundation in Bucharest on 15 January: The British Ambassador, Secretary of State Opris, and Maria Berza, former Secretary of State all spoke enthusiastically from the floor. The report describes what makes the area unique and puts forward proposals for its sympathetic economic development and demonstrates how the future prosperity of the villagers should be intimately linked with conservation. In particular it highlights:

- Cultural tourism, eco-tourism and equestrian tourism: the creation of a network of walking and riding routes linked to village guest houses;
- Village crafts: retraining in old skills and developing sales outlets;
- Organic agriculture: training and investment in organic food production, processing and marketing to help the villagers prosper from agriculture while conserving the environment.

The report concludes by recommending the establishment of a Protected Landscape within the Saxon Village area along the lines of the Lake District.

On **16 January** the Report was launched in Sighisoara at the House on the Rock. The event was attended by the Mayor of Sighisoara, Dorothy Tarrant, Alexandru Gota President of Sighisoara Durabila, and 40 local residents.

A month later on **21 February** the MET held a lunch for 80 people in London at International House, Piccadilly (to launch the Report).

HRH THE PRINCE OF WALES came on a private visit on **1 – 3 May** to Romania to walk among the Saxon villages of Transylvania. The Prince stayed in the Casa cu Cerb hotel, Sighisoara. The first day he visited Closdorf, Roades and Viscri – where he had lunch under the walnut tree in the church precincts – before walking over the hills to Mesendorf and Crit. The following day he visited Biertan, Malancrav and Floresti.

On 17 June The Prince helped raise £12,000 for the Trust in a charity Polo match.



JOURNEYMEN

We are pleased to announce our collaboration with the Journeymen from West Germany – whose house in Sibiu we have helped restore. These brilliant young craftsmen – metal workers, joiners, masons and fine plasterworkers – are based in Sibiu for several months at a time and help us train in the Saxon villages. One important piece of summer work was to install a new roof on the exquisite church in Floresti – once belonging to the Bethlen family. Although this church is deconsecrated, the MET hopes to rebuild more of its destroyed detail – particularly the balconies – and give it new life. Any suggestions for its use will be welcome.

WEBSITE

Our new and recently updated website is *www.eminescutrust.org.uk*. It has details of our restoration work.

CONSERVATION TRAINING

We are proud to announce that a German organisation (GTZ) awarded us first, second and third prizes for our restoration work in Sibiu. This was achieved by our 'A Team' of conservation builders trained under Stuart Preece. In the Spring, three British conservationists will teach a second wave of builders in lime mortar techniques as well as masonry, metalwork and joinery.



House in Malancrav to be restored

DRACULA THEME PARK

The threat of a Dracula Theme Park close to the 15th century citadel town of Sighisoara dominated the year. We alerted the UNESCO World Heritage Centre who, early in 2002, requested that a joint UNESCO-ICOMOS mission be undertaken to the site as soon as possible. In March our patron Sherban Cantacuzino was part of the team who asked that a report be made to the World Heritage Committee at its 26th session. In May, HRH The Prince of Wales spoke to President Iliescu on the subject. In June Jessica Douglas-Home attended as an Observer at the World Heritage Committee in Budapest. UNESCO advised against the Dracula Park site in Sighisoara. In October the matter was resolved by the Romanian Government who, following recommendations by Price Waterhouse, decided that on commercial as well as environmental grounds, the Dracula Park should be nearer Bucharest.

LANDMARK TRUST

We are in close collaboration with the Landmark Trust and have almost completed four Landmark Trust-style houses ready for visitors in the Spring of 2003. These are in the villages of Viscri, Crit, Biertan and Malancrav.

NORWEGIAN GOVERNMENT

The MET has entered a joint programme – called PREM: Preparing a Romanian Village for EU Membership – of training courses and practical work with building restoration and maintenance.

BIERTAN

Restoration of the roof and the exterior of the MET house in the main square was completed in time for the yearly Saxon gathering in September. The interior – our craft shop, café and showcase for the MET restoration work – will be ready by March. The prestigious Abercrombie and Kent's will be bringing a party to visit in 2003.

MALANCRAV

Manor House

Design drawings have been completed. Electricity is in the process of being installed under ground. Work on the building is scheduled to start in April 2003.

Orchard building

The MET received from the British Embassy in Bucharest an apple juicing machine to install in our apple house beside the Manor. The new building and installation will be complete by the end of the year.

Orchard trees

We have received a very generous donation from the Viscountess Boyd Trust. All trees have been pruned to more productive shape and new ones grafted. A seedling nursery has been organised and a report on restoration and development of the orchard is in preparation by Wili Tartler on organic lines. A historic collection of Saxon-Transylvanian apple trees is under consideration. A juicing machine has been installed by Keith Goverd, an expert from Bath.

Bees and honey

Contact has been made with an organic bee keeper interested in establishing his bees in the orchard. This will be very good for pollination and the establishment of organic honey-farming.

Landmark-type house No. 276

The house is now ready for visitors Spring 2003.

Lutheran Church Frescoes

The survey we commissioned from Ioana Munteanu, Brasov-based conservator, through the Horizon Foundation has borne fruit by encouraging the Norwegian Government to help in the restoration of these beautiful 15th century frescoes.

Hungarian Catholic Church

On **8 September,** our Catholic trustee, Mary Walsh, attended the once-a-year service in this tiny green church. Situated in Strada Principala, the street below the Lutheran church, it is in a sad condition with a tree growing on its roof. Emma Dongolo, its caretaker, has inspired us to raise funds for its restoration. We are in close contact with the Architectural Office of the Diocese in Alba Iulia. Although we have yet to find the money, we will begin over the winter months to put on a new roof to stop further deterioration. In the Spring – after a fundraising supper with the help of Judith Majlath – we hope to start repair of the main fabric of the church and its parsonage.



Lutheran Church altarpiece panel, Malancrav



Endangered Hungarian Catholic Church

ECO TOURISM

The Trust has been helping village guest house owners to install showers and interior WCs. There have been several small tours into the Saxon Villages initiated by the MET. Many of these were provided by Lucy Abel Smith (*lucy@realityandbeyond.co.uk*) who supplies individually crafted tours. This year she brought David and Martha Mlnaric, Michael and Arabella Heathcoat-Amory, Frances and Hamish Cairncross, and Nicholas and Diana Baring – all of whom gave generous donations to the MET on return home. The Barings were our first equestrian tourists – the Trust has three horses – and rode the 30 miles from Viscri to Malancrav.



EXHIBITION

Our restoration season ended in our two communes on schedule with 18 facades completed. On **28 October** a two week exhibition of our Saxon Whole Village Programme in the "Ion Mincu" University of Architecture, Bucharest took place. Prime Minister Nastase and Secretary of State Opris both visited and President Iliescu held a celebration in Sinaia. The exhibition plans to tour other Romanian towns and possibly travel to England during the Romanian-British season 2004.

FILM LAUNCH

Angus McQueen held a preview on **2 December** for his film "The Last Peasants". The MET – who collaborated in its making – invited friends to attend. It will be shown on Channel 4 in January 2003 .

IN SHORT

- We gave a grant to the young cellist Cristina Gyarmati from Arpad, Western Romania, to attend an Easter course at the Yehudi Menuhin School in Surrey.
- We helped the Solomon Ensemble record a CD of music by Georges Enescu and supported a concert at the Wigmore Hall.
- We gave a grant to the Royal College of Music to create a tour to study music in Romanian villages.
- We are pleased to announce the safe arrival in one of our lorries of seven boxes of Hebrew books, donated from the British Library to the Jewish Studies Department of the Babes Bolyai University of Cluj. Its director, Professor Laszlo Gyemant, points out that this department is the only such academic institution in Transylvania.
- We sadly announce the departure of Nat Page.
- We welcome Roxanna Macdonald – conservation architect and project manager – as our director in Romania.
- We helped a Belgian study of Flora and Fauna in the Malancrav area, enabling us to enhance our Akeroyd botannical report.
- We planted avenues of poplars on both roads into Viscri, as well as into Crit.
- Through the generous donation of Glaxo, we provided a car for the Bunesti commune doctor.
- Through a grant, we are enabling Sighisoara to enter Agenda 21.
- We have received support from the Ratiu Foundation for a report on the future of Transylvania.
- Co-operation with Pro Patrimonio – Romania's National Trust – thrives. We have been helping with their house No18, in Viscri.

BOOKS FOR SALE

Fax order to: Tel 0207 792 9998

The Plight of the Saxons of Transylvania: W. Blacker - £5
Guest Houses in Transylvania – and walks among the fortified churches in the area of Medias - £5
The Saxon Villages of Transylvania: Kim Wilkie -£10
Once Upon Another Time: Jessica Douglas-Home -£15
Romania: Cross-Roads of Cultures: John Villiers - £4
Postage and Packing extra